

Bridge: A Trick-Taking Game

Two partnerships, 52 cards, thirteen tricks to win: the side that bids highest in the auction chooses how the hand is played.



1 The deck and the partnerships

Bridge is a partnership game: the player across the table is your partner, so it's **North-South against East-West**. The deck has **52 cards** in four suits of 13, from the ace down to the two.

♠ J8 ♥ AQJ43 ♦ KQ3 ♣ A98

one hand: 13 cards

♠ Spades ♥ Hearts ♦ Diamonds ♣ Clubs

Honors: A K Q J 10. Spot cards: 9 down to 2.

No cards in a suit: a **void**. One card: a **singleton**. Two: a **doubleton**.

2 The trick

The first card played is the **opening lead**. The others, in clockwise order, must **follow suit**: play a card of the same suit.

The highest card of the suit led wins the trick.

N ♠ 3

W ♠ K E ♠ 7

S ♠ A

West leads the K♠, North plays the 3, East the 7: South wins with the **ace**. A player out of the suit **discards** another card, and a discard never wins the trick.

3 Dummy and declarer

After the opening lead, **dummy** lays its cards face up on the table, sorted by suit, and takes no further part: its partner, **declarer**, chooses every card.

Declarer sees 26 cards: their own 13 and dummy's 13. That makes it possible to plan the play.

The defenders see only their own cards and dummy's, never their partner's.

4 Trumps or notrump

Trumps: one suit gets special power. A player out of the suit led can **ruff** with a trump and win the trick.

Ruffing: only when you can't follow suit, and never compulsory. If two players ruff, the higher trump wins.

Notrump (NT): no suit can ruff. A player out of a suit can only discard.

5 The auction and the contract

2♥

Through an auction a side commits to taking a number of tricks: the highest bid chooses how the hand is played. The number counts tricks **beyond the first six**: "2♥" means **at least 8 tricks, with hearts as trumps**.

From the top: NT > ♠ > ♥ > ♦ > ♣ after 1♥ you can bid 1♠; 1♦ and 1♣ need the 2 level

When a bid is followed by three passes, that bid becomes the contract.

6 Scoring

EACH TRICK BID BEYOND SIX	
Clubs ♣ and diamonds ♦	20
Hearts ♥ and spades ♠	30
Notrump	40 the first, 30 the rest
Game: the tricks bid are worth at least 100.	
3NT	
4♥	
4♠	
5♣	
5♦	

BONUSES AND PENALTIES	NON VUL · VUL
Game	300 · 500
Small slam (12 tricks)	500 · 750
Grand slam (13 tricks)	1000 · 1500
Each trick down	50 · 100